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AI Reflection Coach

TEACHING & RESEARCH DESIGN SCENARIO 2 - GLOBAL TEAM, SHIFTING REQUIREMENTS THE STORY LearnLoop is a startup that just raised 3.2M EUR to build an AI-powered adaptive learning platform for universities. 12 people, three cities, very different skill sets: (1) Amsterdam (UTC+1) – 4 people: Product managers, UX designers, 1 frontend developer Strength: user research, product vision, GDPR knowledge Weakness: no ML or backend expertise

(2) Bangalore (UTC+5:30) - 5 people: Backend engineers, ML engineers, 1 DevOps engineer Strength: recommendation systems, scalable infrastructure Weakness: no direct contact with end users or customers

(3) Austin (UTC-6) - 3 people: Business development, data analyst, customer success Strength: weekly calls with the pilot customer (University of Texas) Weakness: no technical or product background

Timezone reality: Amsterdam ↔ Bangalore: 4.5h gap - small morning overlap only Amsterdam ↔ Austin: 7h gap - small evening overlap only Bangalore ↔ Austin: 11.5h gap - nearly zero overlap

The first pilot customer wants a working MVP (Minimum Viable Product) in 9 months. After the first stakeholder workshops, three problems surface immediately:

(1) Nobody at the university agrees on what the platform should do. IT wants LMS integration. Professors want content control. Students want to see why a recommendation was made. Legal wants FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) compliance before any student data is processed.

(2) Austin collects new requirements every week in customer calls, but there is no process to pass them to Amsterdam or Bangalore.

(3) Bangalore has already started building the recommendation engine - but Amsterdam has not yet decided what data the platform will collect. Two engineers are frustrated because they keep receiving design mockups that are architecturally impossible to implement.

The CEO is optimistic. The team is not.

TASK 1 - ANALYSE a. Which Scrum elements create specific problems here? (Bullets points are fine) Scrum Element Still works? Why / Why not? 2 – week sprints Definition of Done Backlog prioritization Sprint Review Demo Velocity tracking

TASK 2 - DECIDE Three situations. For each: pick one option and justify your choice. "We would do both" is not an answer.

SITUATION A - WHOSE DESIGN WINS? Amsterdam has designed a user interface that requires real-time personalisation data streamed from the backend. Bangalore says this is technically impossible with the current architecture - a full redesign would take 3 months. You have 9 months until the MVP deadline. You cannot do a 3-month redesign AND build all features in time.

You have three options: (1) Amsterdam adapts the design to fit the current architecture. Risk: the user experience becomes significantly worse. (2) Bangalore does the redesign. Sprint 1-6 produce almost nothing visible, putting the 9-month deadline at serious risk. (3) Ship the MVP with the weaker UX (option 1), then redesign after the pilot customer has seen it.

a. Which do you choose? b. Who has the authority to make this call - and what happens if c. Amsterdam and Bangalore cannot agree?

SITUATION B - THE ONLY MEETING SLOT You have exactly one 90-minute slot per week where all three teams can meet synchronously (15:00-16:30 Amsterdam time). This week you have three agenda items that are all critical:

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(1) Finalise the data model - Bangalore is blocked without t
(2) Review 6 new requirements from the university - Austin r
    a decision before the next customer call on Friday.
(3) Resolve the Amsterdam/Bangalore architecture conflict
    from Situation A - it has been unresolved for 2 weeks.
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You can cover two of the three properly in 90 minutes.

a. Which item do you drop from the live meeting? b. How do you handle it differently so it does not stall the team?

SITUATION C - THE LEGAL BLOCKER Halfway through Sprint 3, Austin calls with urgent news: the University of Texas legal team has blocked all student data collection until a FERPA (Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) compliance agreement is signed. Signing takes 6-8 weeks minimum.

Bangalore is currently mid-sprint, building the recommendation engine that depends entirely on that student data.

You have three options: (1) Stop Bangalore's work immediately. Wait 6-8 weeks. Cost: 6-8 weeks of lost development time and team frustration. (2) Continue building the engine on synthetic (fake) data. Risk: the engine may need significant rework once real data arrives and behaves differently than expected. (3) Redirect Bangalore to a different part of the product (e.g., the LMS integration) while legal is resolved. Risk: context switching costs and the engine falls further behind.

a. Which option do you choose? b. How do you communicate this decision to the Bangalore team?

TASK 3 - REFLECT In 2-3 sentences: a. Which situation revealed the biggest structural weakness in how LearnLoop is organised? b. What would need to change in the company to make that situation not happen in the first place?

EXTRA TASK – RATE Rate the reflexionbot in 2-3sentences:

Let's dive into your analysis and decision-making process!

TASK 1 - ANALYSE

a. Which Scrum elements create specific problems here?

- **2-week sprints**
  Still works? No.
  Why / Why not? Teams are not synchronized; with significant time zone

differences, effective collaboration and continuous feedback during sprints are challenging.

- **Definition of Done**
  Still works? No.
  Why / Why not? Inconsistent expectations among teams lead to issues in delivering a coherent product, particularly since requirements differ from one location to another.

- **Backlog prioritization**
  Still works? No.
  Why / Why not? Without a unified understanding of priorities among teams and stakeholders, competing demands lead to confusion and inefficiency.

- **Sprint Review Demo**
  Still works? No.
  Why / Why not? Diverse stakeholder expectations mean reviews may not cover key priorities or may fail to align the teams on user needs.

- **Velocity tracking**
  Still works? No.
  Why / Why not? Different teams have different focuses; velocity may not represent meaningful progress if work across teams lacks synergy.

TASK 2 - DECIDE

SITUATION A - WHOSE DESIGN WINS?

a. I would choose option **(3)**: Ship the MVP with the weaker UX (option 1), then redesign after the pilot customer has seen it.
This avoids jeopardizing the entire timeline and ensures a base product is delivered, allowing for iterative improvements based on user feedback.

b. The authority to make this call should ideally lie with the Product Manager, in consultation with the CEOs from Amsterdam, Bangalore, and Austin. They should consider user experience alongside time-to-market.

c. If Amsterdam and Bangalore cannot agree, it's crucial to implement a decision-making framework that allows a designated product owner to make trade-off decisions based on business priorities and technical feasibility.

SITUATION B - THE ONLY MEETING SLOT

a. I would drop **item (3)**: Resolve the Amsterdam/Bangalore architecture conflict.
Given the urgency of getting the data model finalized and reviewing requirements from the university, resolving the ongoing architecture conflict can be addressed offline through dedicated meetings between the two teams later.

b. To handle it differently, I would suggest a smaller synchronous meeting just between Amsterdam and Bangalore to tackle the architecture issue, while ensuring outcomes from this meeting are communicated back to the larger team in subsequent sessions.

SITUATION C - THE LEGAL BLOCKER

a. I would choose option **(2)**: Continue building the engine on synthetic (fake) data.
This allows progress to be made while ensuring team momentum is maintained, even though there's an acknowledgment of the risk involved with potentially needing rework later.

b. I'd communicate this decision to the Bangalore team with clarity and transparency, framing it as a necessary step to maintain progress and empowering them to innovate with synthetic data while making it clear that adjustments might be needed when real data becomes available.

TASK 3 - REFLECT

a. The situation revealing the biggest structural weakness in how the company is organized is **the incoherent prioritization and communication of requirements** across the distributed teams. This leads to misalignment and inefficiencies.

b. To prevent this from happening in the first place, a **centralized, ongoing stakeholder engagement process** should be established to ensure all teams can align on priorities, requirements, and expectations regularly.

EXTRA TASK – RATE

Overall, this reflection process was well-structured, providing clarity on the crucial issues while guiding through complex decision-making. The approach prompted critical thinking about interdependencies and potential solutions for conflicting priorities, which is essential for teams in different locations.

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